

Civic Density and American Political Behavior: How Residential Civic Diversity Shapes Political Participation

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Introduction

Few concepts within the study of politics hold as much purchase as the critical nature of civic life in shaping citizen's political engagement. When individuals are recruited, convened, and informed by civic organizations, participation is thought to follow. While this foundational truism is oft-repeated as a logical and necessary truth, historically it has been limited empirically by measures of the demand side of civic engagement: individual trust, networks, and dispositions, all of which have been in decline for some time [CITE]. Far less attention is placed on the *supply side* of civic opportunity; the civic infrastructure that may be available or present in a community, regardless of individual membership.

Generally, this demand side of civic engagement focuses on the effects of membership in civic associations has to an individual's propensity to be an active participant in democratic processes [CITE]. But to what extent do the meso-level features of civic organizations; the features that constitute the communities that they are embedded in, shape this propensity in ways that are distinct from individual-level membership?

Contemporary scholarship on civic associations, by focusing on the characteristics of those who join, necessarily dial in on the ways that this membership can predict other types of behavior. But as recent work by Stephanie Ternullo argues, "place politics - or the correlation between where people live and their partisanship - exists at multiple geographic scales." One way at getting at this, which is Ternullo's approach, is to compare similarly situated locations with differing partisan affiliations. Another approach, the one we take here, is to connect data on civic organizations aggregated to a local level with individual level survey data to track how the features of living within a community with a different composition of civic associations affects canonical measures of political participation, namely voter turnout and presidential vote choice.

To do this, we construct a dataset that merges data recently compiled by Martin de Vries, Hahrie Han, and Jae Yeon Kim that measures civic opportunity at the county level to the 2024 wave of the Cooperative Post-Election Study (CMPS) to more deeply understand what we call supply-side civic engagement. We find that living in a county with a higher density of civic opportunities leads to a reduction in support for Donald Trump in the 2024 election. We also find that this same measure also predicts an increase in voter turnout, with a particularly strong impact for younger voters.

While previous literature has ably and thoughtfully explored the relationship between social capital and political engagement, we believe that we are the first to pair data on the universe of civic organizations with rich, fine-grained data on political behavior, giving us leverage to mine key insights into a question that is similar, yet distinct to what is currently asked in the literature. Rather than asking how civic organizations drive political participation, we ask how living in a place that is more concentrated with these organizations shape political behavior.

This contributes to the literature on social capital by articulating an alternative story that goes beyond the individual-level effects of civic bonds as driving these effects, instead focusing on ways that the formation of these bonds might be endogenous to the type of community in which they are forged. It contributes the literature on political behavior by exploring new tools to understand how local context shapes political decision-making in ways that are tied and untied from cognitive, psychologically-based models.

Civic Density: A New Tool for a Canonical Question

Part of the reason for this relative lack of scholarly attention is the lack of tools to do so. The demand side measures are largely drawn from self-reported survey measures that reflect individual's perception of their relationship to the state and their energy (or lack thereof) to participate in the democratic process. This is both substantively important and methodologically intuitive. But, as recent work on the nationalization of American politics, increased polarization, and the relationship between increased financial precarity and political decision making [CITE] highlights, people's individual choices are embedded within communities. Understanding the dynamics of local politics is thus important not only to evaluate demographic comparisons but also to understand what are the conditions under which people's decisions can be changed

Data and Methods

Does Civic Density Predict Trump Support?

Civic Density and Voter Turnout: A Youth Accelerant

Civic Density and Partisan Identification

Discussion

Conclusion and Next Steps